



Novelty not good design

Take this mirror chair designed by Kai Linke makes you wonder how people are supposed to use it. Unless of course the designer had some very ahem intimate use for it.

a sports car loved by the female populace. We wonder why some men prefer not to be seen in one of these nimble machines.

Product differentiation

Form factor is very important when it comes to product differentiation. Companies that have a handful of products need to follow a strict differentiation policy in terms of form factors. Cowon for instance has a few PMPs in its portfolio. Each one is unique in form and design. When this is not followed it can lead to confusion in the consumers mind. One product might end up cannibalising the other or eating into each other's market segment or share. The Windows Mobile platform may not be something to write home about. But as Mr. Sumeet Gugrani, Director – Mobile Communications Business, at Microsoft put it "Windows Mobile 6.5 comes in the widest range of form factors through our partnership with a number of OEMs. You have everything from candy bar to sliders to QWERTY to full touch. All options are available." It can have disastrous consequences when differentiation is not followed in the public utilities domain. Take the freshly minted batch of coins from the Indian treasury. The rupees one and two denomination coins do follow certain design norms like keeping in mind the illiterate sections of society by clearly displaying value using symbology depicting hands holding up the appropriate number of fingers. Yet the coins are so similar in size and shape that we can't

differentiate them quickly. The older generation of coins were so different that you could tell them apart just by feel and touch.

Uninvited Innovation

Sometimes mundane objects can go through a revamp with the thought of bettering them. The adage 'old is gold' holds true and some tried and tested things should be left alone. Questioning tradition for being irrelevant is fine but respecting it for its longevity of existence is also a virtue. The perfect example of something that doesn't need reinventing, apart from the wheel, is perhaps the chair. We've been sitting on these things for ages now and there's not much room for something radical to be done there as the human form hasn't changed much over the past 2,000 years or so. A while ago, we came across a design called Stenstool



Sega Saturn didn't find too many game developers

Chair by Jimmy Kessler. It's basically a stool that's a rock supported by four spindly legs. Why would you want to sit on a rock? After all, it was these that prompted our ancestors to invent chairs in the first place! Another example is the Sidewaysbike by inventor Michael Killian. You sit in the centre but face and pedal sideways! Wonder how that would work. Check out sidewaysbike.com for pictures and videos of this weird contraption.

Ignoring scalability

When you build something, it should form a platform on which further improvement can take place. Take the case of pagers. "Pagers lasted for sometime but never reached the potential they were touted to reach they were not the easiest to use and not very intuitive. They were banking on text for communication thereby limiting the usage amongst literate population. With the advent of mobile telephony they

Feature Creep

A designing pet peeve in which products are packed to the brim with features. The more things you ask a device to do, the harder it becomes for you to make it perform its core function.

just disappeared", says Anirudh Maitra of Pictualize Edutech, a start-up engaged in designing educational and learning enhancement products. Another one would be the 1995 offering, Sega Saturn. It's often criticised as one of the worst gaming consoles in history. It was built on the cutting edge of technology yet something went wrong. The complexity of its dual Hitachi CPUs caused problems in game development. Soon game designers started moving towards the easier and cheaper PlayStation platform. The problem was no scalability thus sealing Saturn's downfall.

The me too effect

Have you noticed that most MP3 players coming to the market lately look conspicuously like iPods. The same round dial, similar screen size and all other attributes, only they look like country cousins of the original. 'If it worked for them why can't it work for us?' – is perhaps the thought design houses are struggling with. Since the CoverFlow format of displaying elements became popular, you find it in every other place from TV programming to websites to even print. Websites today follow the tried and tested web 2.0 sensibilities and end up looking like they came out of the same mould. If it works, it works but here is the caveat - at some point people are bound to get up and say – hey this is getting boring now. What then? **d**



Whatever happened to comfort?



One of the many iPod look alikes